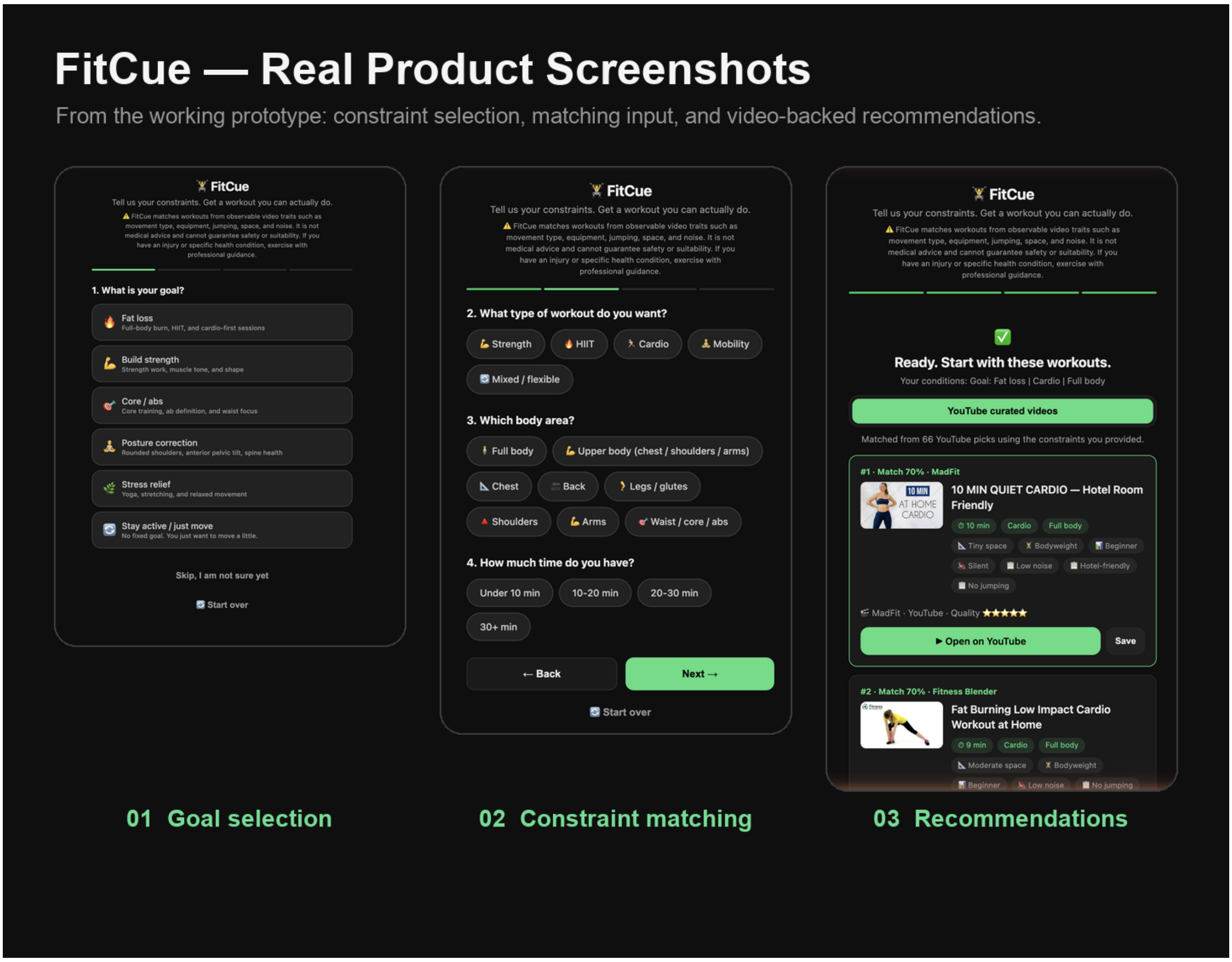
FitCue Case Study

Reducing Constraint Friction in Fitness

One-line judgement: People do not need more workout videos. They need confidence that today's workout is feasible, safe, and worth starting.



Role & Scope

Role: Product lead / founder-style product discovery

Scope: Problem framing, market research, competitor analysis, user segment definition, prototype direction, validation design

Stage: Early discovery and prototype validation

Output: Web prototype, structured video-tagging logic, validation plan, go / no-go business judgement

Portfolio Exhibits

Use these alongside the written case study:

- One-page visual showcase: a portfolio-ready page with problem framing, segment narrowing, prototype flow, strategic trade-offs and validation plan.
- Showcase pack: the asset checklist for screenshots, captions and LinkedIn/PDF layout.
- Prototype screenshot montage: three-screen visual flow for quick portfolio scanning.

- Interactive prototype: the working mobile-first prototype used as the product artifact.

Context

Fitness content has become abundant. YouTube, TikTok, Bilibili, Keep, Nike Training Club and many independent creators already offer thousands of free or low-cost workout videos. At first glance, the problem looks solved: users can search for almost any workout.

However, the original idea behind FitCue came from a different observation. Many people still fail to start a workout, even when they are motivated and surrounded by content. Their blocker is not a lack of supply. It is the effort required to choose something suitable for today's real-life constraints.

The initial product idea was simple: users select workout type, available time, space, equipment and restrictions, then the system recommends suitable public workout videos. During discovery, I reframed this from a generic "fitness video recommendation" product into a more specific decision-support tool for users whose workout conditions change frequently.

Problem

The core user problem is not "I cannot find fitness content." It is:

> *"I want to work out today, but I do not know which video I can safely and realistically follow under my current constraints."*

This matters because many users face different constraints before each workout:

- They only have 10-20 minutes.
- They are in a hotel room, dorm room, bedroom corner or small living room.
- They cannot jump because of noise, neighbours or family.
- They have no equipment, or only a yoga mat, dumbbells or resistance bands.
- They are returning after pregnancy, injury, illness or years away from exercise.

For these users, a generic search such as "20 minute workout" is too broad. A more realistic query might be "postpartum-safe, low-noise, no-jumping, 15-minute, small-space, beginner-friendly workout". Most video platforms are not designed for that level of structured constraint matching.

Research

I used three layers of research to pressure-test the idea.

First, I ran a product-thesis review to separate the user pain from the business opportunity. The strongest argument for the product was that large video platforms optimise for watch time, while FitCue would optimise for workout completion. The strongest challenge was that a pure recommendation layer might have weak retention, low defensibility and limited willingness to pay.

Second, I analysed user segments and found that the product should not target all fitness users. Standard gym-goers often have stable routines and low need for a separate recommendation tool. The stronger segments were "constraint-changing users": business travellers, new mothers, dorm students, people training in small homes, and midlife restarters with safety concerns.

Third, I compared the competitive landscape. Existing fitness apps are strong at plans, creator content or habit tracking, but weak at matching public videos to highly specific constraints. Fitbod is the closest adjacent product because it helps users decide what to train today, but it keeps the workout and behaviour loop inside its own app. FitCue's lightweight link-based model is easier to launch, but less defensible.

Insight

Users do not need more fitness content. They need confidence that today's workout fits their constraints.

This changed the product from a content-discovery idea into a constraint-friction product.

Hypothesis

If FitCue can translate a user's daily constraints into 1-3 safe, feasible workout recommendations, then constraint-changing users will be more likely to start a workout and return when their conditions change again.

The key success criteria were:

- Users can express their constraints faster than they can search manually.
- Users trust the safety tags enough to start.
- Users accept being directed to YouTube, Bilibili or another public video platform.
- The product creates repeat value because constraints change over time.

Strategic Decision

I chose a lightweight matching layer rather than a full AI coach, training-plan app or proprietary content platform.

The reason was focus. The riskiest assumption was not whether workout videos exist. It was whether structured condition matching creates enough extra value over search. Building a full AI coach or original content library would have delayed the learning cycle and introduced unnecessary complexity.

The MVP direction became:

- A mobile-first web app / PWA.
- Structured inputs for goal, time, space, equipment, difficulty and restrictions.
- A manually curated and tagged seed video library.
- 1-3 recommendations rather than an endless feed.
- Clear match reasons and safety labels.
- Public video links rather than embedded or copied content.

This also reduced legal and operational risk because the product behaves more like a specialised search layer than a content host.

Trade-offs

The most important product trade-off was speed versus defensibility.

A link-based recommendation product is fast to build, low cost and easy to validate. It also matches existing user behaviour because people are already comfortable watching workouts on public video platforms.

But the same model creates strategic weakness. Once the user clicks away to YouTube or Bilibili, FitCue loses behavioural data. That limits personalisation, retention loops and long-term defensibility. In contrast, products like Fitbod can improve because the workout happens inside the app.

This led to a clear business judgement: FitCue is more credible as a focused lifestyle business or indie product than as a VC-scale company in its current form. To become a larger business, it would likely need to move from "recommend videos" to "generate and track personalised workouts with video support".

Validation Signals

At this stage, I treated validation carefully and did not overclaim traction.

The strongest signal was problem-segment fit. In assumption testing, the highest-need segments were users whose conditions changed often or whose safety concerns made video choice risky. Simulated diary and recommendation tests suggested that complex-constraint users had much higher condition variation than ordinary gym users, while ordinary gym users showed weak interest. This supported the segmentation decision, but it still needs to be validated with real users.

The second signal was concept clarity. The product became easier to explain when positioned around "what can I safely do today?" rather than "fitness video recommendation". Safety labels such as no-jumping, knee-friendly, postpartum-friendly and small-space became trust signals, not just filters.

The third signal was business realism. Competitive and unit-economics analysis showed that the user problem is real, but the current model has weak moat, low ARPU potential and strong substitutes. This was an important product decision: continue only as a low-cost validation project, not as a high-burn startup thesis.

The next validation step should be a real-world concierge MVP:

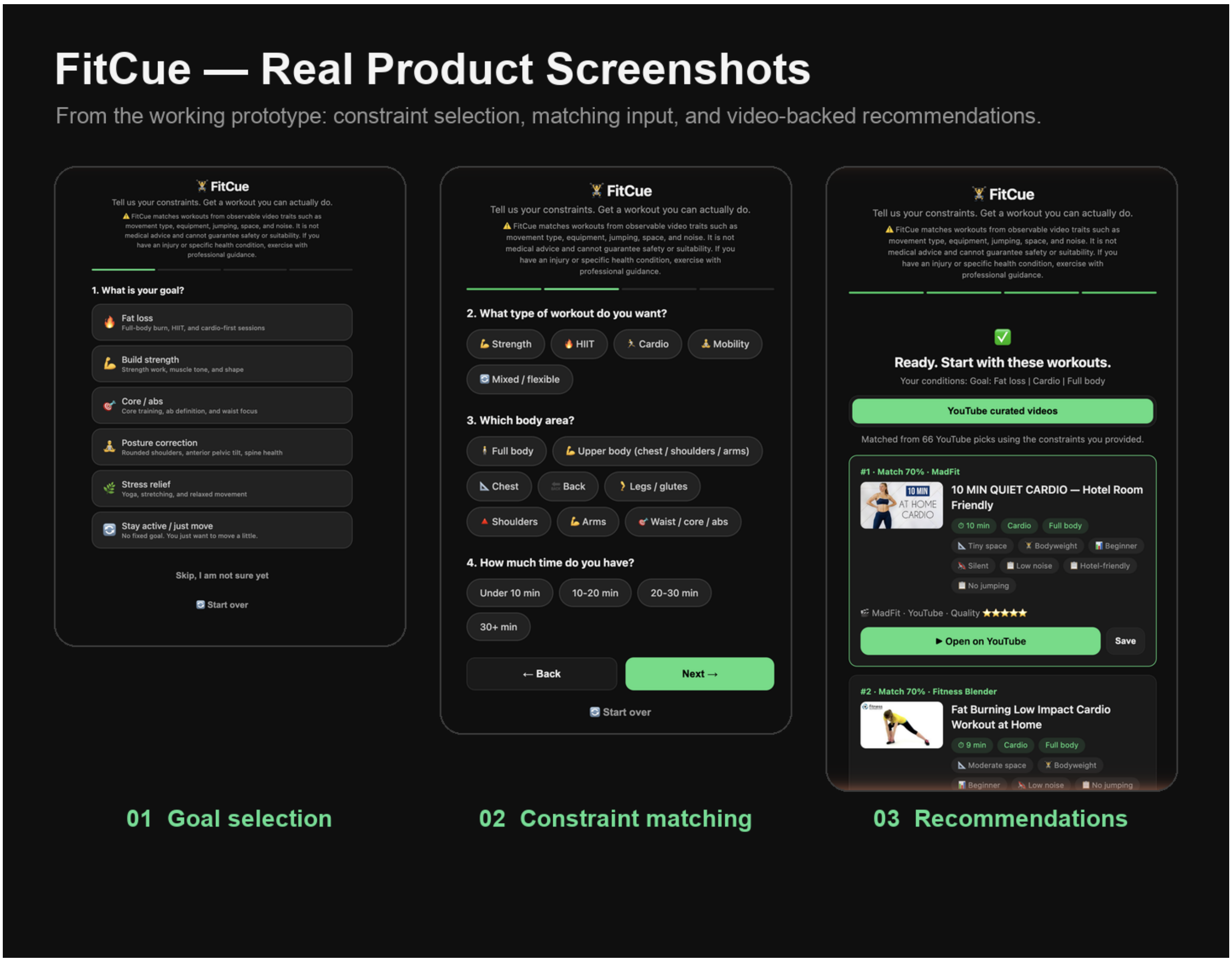
- 20 users record workout conditions for two weeks.
- 10 complex-constraint users receive manual video recommendations.
- Measure first-use completion, repeat requests, safety trust, and whether link-out is acceptable.

What I Learned

The biggest learning was that a product can solve a real user problem and still be the wrong business shape.

FitCue uncovered a genuine user need: reducing constraint friction before action. But the discovery process also showed that user value, retention, defensibility and monetisation must be evaluated separately. A product manager's job is not to defend the original idea. It is to keep narrowing the problem until the right product shape becomes visible.

I also learned that reducing choices can be more valuable than adding options. In a content-saturated category, the product experience should not feel like another feed. It should feel like relief: "Here is one workout you can actually do today."



What I Would Do Next

I would run the two-week concierge MVP before investing further in automation. If users return for recommendations when their constraints change, I would expand the manually tagged library and test a simple paid tier around safety filters and saved preferences.

If repeat usage is weak, I would not force the product into a larger roadmap. I would either keep it as a lightweight SEO-led tool or transfer the underlying insight, constraint-based decision reduction, into a category with stronger retention and monetisation.

One-page LinkedIn Featured Version

FitCue: Reducing Constraint Friction in Fitness

Context: Fitness content is abundant, but many users still fail to start because choosing the right workout under today's constraints is hard.

Problem: The blocker is not content supply. It is confidence: "Can I safely and realistically do this workout today?"

Research: I reviewed the idea through product-thesis pressure testing, segment analysis and competitor research. The strongest users were not standard gym-goers, but people with changing constraints: travellers, new mothers, dorm students, small-space users and midlife restarters.

Insight: Users do not need more workout videos. They need confidence that today's workout is feasible.

Strategy: I chose a lightweight condition-matching product instead of an AI coach or content platform. Users enter time, space, equipment and restrictions, then receive 1-3 public workout links with clear match reasons and safety labels.

Trade-off: The link-based model is fast to validate but weakly defensible because the behaviour loop happens outside the product. This made FitCue more suitable as a low-cost indie/lifestyle business unless it later evolves into in-app workout generation and tracking.

Validation: Early assumption testing supported the problem-segment fit, especially for complex-constraint users. The next step is a real concierge MVP with 20 diary participants and 10 manual-recommendation users.

Learning: Reducing decision friction can be more valuable than adding content. The right product is not another feed, but a confident answer to: "What can I actually do today?"